

Qroo Paul's Spanish Master Course

Relative Pronouns Summary

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In this lesson, you'll learn how to connect ideas using **relative pronouns** in Spanish. These pronouns help avoid repetition and make your Spanish more natural and fluent.

◆ What Are Relative Pronouns?

Relative pronouns are words like **that, who, whom, which, what** in English. They connect clauses and refer back to a noun or idea.

Example (English):

The man **who lives next door** is my uncle.

In Spanish, relative pronouns include:

que – that, who, which

quien / quienes – who, whom (people only)

el que / la que / los que / las que – the one(s) that / who

el cual / la cual / los cuales / las cuales – formal version of the above

lo que / lo cual – what / that which (referring to ideas, not nouns)

1. QUE – That, Who, Which

This is the most common relative pronoun. It works for **people or things** and is used in **restrictive clauses** (clauses that are essential to the sentence and not set off by commas).

✓ Examples:

- El estudiante **que ganó el concurso** es muy talentoso.
(The student who won the contest is very talented.)
- La casa **que compraron** está en el centro.
(The house that they bought is downtown.)
- El libro **que leí** fue interesante.
(The book I read was interesting.)

! You cannot omit *que* in Spanish.

In English: *The book I read...* ← possible

In Spanish: *El libro que leí...* ← **you must include "que"**

2. QUIEN / QUIENES – Who, Whom (people only)

Use these only for **people**, and only in two cases:

- After a **preposition**
- In **non-restrictive clauses** (extra information set off by commas)

✓ Examples (after preposition):

- Salimos con los vecinos **con quienes** siempre cenamos.
(We went out with the neighbors **with whom** we always have dinner.)
- La mujer **a quien** vi ayer trabaja aquí.
(The woman **whom I saw** yesterday works here.)

✓ Examples (non-restrictive clause):

- Mi hermano, **quien vive en Londres**, viene de visita.
(My brother, **who lives in London**, is coming to visit.)

⊘ Don't use *quien* in restrictive clauses:

- Incorrect: *La mujer quien trabaja aquí...*
 - Correct: *La mujer **que** trabaja aquí...*
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3. EL QUE / LA QUE / LOS QUE / LAS QUE – The one(s) that / who

These agree in gender and number with the noun they refer to. Use them:

- After **prepositions**
- In **non-restrictive clauses**
- To express **the one(s) who/that...**

✓ Examples:

- La persona **de la que me enamoré** acaba de llegar.
(The person **I fell in love with** just arrived.)

- **Los que estudian** más van a pasar.
(The ones who study more will pass.)
 - Mis amigos, **los que viven cerca**, vienen hoy.
(My friends, the ones who live nearby, are coming today.)
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4. EL CUAL / LA CUAL / LOS CUALES / LAS CUALES – Formal alternative

These work **just like** *el que* forms, but sound **more formal**. They're often used:

- In **writing**
- After **long prepositional phrases**
- When the relative pronoun is separated from the noun by several words

✓ Examples:

- Las líneas de comunicación **por las cuales** mantenemos contacto están fallando.
(The lines of communication **through which** we stay in touch are failing.)
- Los árboles **bajo los cuales** jugaba de niño han crecido.
(The trees **under which** I used to play have grown.)

✓ Non-restrictive example:

- Mi prima, **la cual vive en México**, viene de visita.
(My cousin, **who lives in Mexico**, is coming to visit.)
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5. NO DANGLING PREPOSITIONS IN SPANISH

In English, we often leave prepositions hanging at the end:

- The person **I talked about**
- The man **I went with**

Spanish does **not** allow this. You must include the preposition **before** the relative pronoun, and often use *el que* or *quien*.

✓ Examples:

- La persona **de la que hablé** está aquí.
(The person **I talked about** is here.)

- La mujer **con la que fui a la fiesta** está allí.
(The woman **I went to the party with** is over there.)
- El hombre **sobre el que escribiste** acaba de llegar.
(The man **you wrote about** just arrived.)

! Don't translate literally:

La persona que hablé de ← incorrect

*La persona **de la que hablé*** ← correct

6. LO QUE / LO CUAL – What / That which

Use *lo que* to refer back to **ideas or entire clauses**, not specific nouns. It means **what, the thing that, or that which**. *Lo cual* is more formal and used when referring back to a specific clause.

✓ Examples with LO QUE:

- **Lo que quiero** es paz.
(What I want is peace.)
- Quiero hablar de **lo que pasó** ayer.
(I want to talk about what happened yesterday.)
- **Lo que más me gusta** es pasar tiempo contigo.
(What I like most is spending time with you.)

✓ Examples with LO CUAL (formal):

- Ella llegó tarde, **lo cual** sorprendió a todos.
(She arrived late, **which** surprised everyone.)



Tip: In speech and informal writing, stick with *lo que*. It's more common and natural.

Final Notes:

- **Always include the relative pronoun in Spanish**—don't leave it out like we do in English.
- Learn verbs **with their prepositions** (e.g., *enamorarse de*, *hablar de*, *quejarse de*) to use them properly with relative pronouns.
- "**Que**" should be your default choice. Learn the others gradually as you recognize specific patterns and situations.